

Indian Philosophical Systems – Non-Vedic Schools

3.6 Overview – Non-Vedic Philosophical Systems

- Do not accept the Vedas as an authoritative text
- Do not accept the entity Isvara (God)
- Three prominent schools: Jaina, Bauddha (Buddhist), Carvaka

3.6.1 Jaina School of Philosophy

Origins & Key Figures

- 'Jaina' from Sanskrit root 'ji' – to conquer; one who has subdued passions and gained mastery
- Recognises 24 Tirthankaras (prophets/masters), from Vrishabhadeva to Mahavira
- Mahavira – the 24th Tirthankara, lived in the 6th century BCE
- Two main sects: Svetambaras (white-clad) and Digambaras (sky-clad) – differ in rituals; agree on philosophy
- Both sects accept the Tattvarthasutra (composed by Umasvati, 2nd–3rd century CE) as authority
- Refuses to acknowledge Vedas and the notion of a supreme God

Ontology – Fundamental Categories of Being

- Soul (Jiva)
- Matter (Pudgala)
- Space (Akasha)
- Time (Kala)
- Principle of Motion (Dharma)
- Principle of Rest (Adharma)

Jivas are infinite. Our knowledge of any substance is limited and relative, not absolute.

Syad-vada – Conditional Predication

- Reality cannot be captured perfectly by language alone
- 'Syat' in Sanskrit = 'maybe' / 'from a certain point of view'
- Jaina school lists 7 possibilities for truth values – enables analysis of claims as relative assertions
- Analogous to six blind men describing an elephant – each partially right, none fully right

Karma and Liberation

- Birth-death cycle attributed to tiny particles of matter (Pudgala) embedded in the Jiva – this is karma

- Karma attracts based on passions; passions are triggered by karmic particles already bonded to the Jiva – a self-reinforcing cycle
- Liberation = purifying the Jiva of karmic matter so its inherent blissful nature can radiate

Three Gems (Ratnatraya) – Path to Liberation

- Right Faith (Samyak Shraddha) – utmost importance; false convictions diminish value of all action
- Right Knowledge (Samyak Jnana) – understanding of Jaina philosophy
- Right Conduct (Samyak Charitra) – controlling passions; Ahimsa is the most important conduct

By diligently practising ethical restraints and ascetic disciplines, karmas drop away and the pure knowledge of the Jiva begins to radiate.

3.6.2 Bauddha (Buddhist) School of Philosophy

Origins

- Based on teachings of Gautama Buddha, born Siddhartha in 4th–5th century BCE
- Two main forms: Northern Buddhism (Mahayana) – Nepal, Tibet, China, Japan; Southern Buddhism (Theravada) – Sri Lanka, SE Asia
- Gautama moved by suffering of life-death cycle; enlightenment showed the path to Nirvana

Four Noble Truths (Catvari Arya-Satyani)

- There is suffering – birth, decay, illness, death, not getting what we desire are all suffering
- There is a cause of suffering – thirst (tanha) leads to rebirth; thirst for pleasure, existence, prosperity
- Cessation of suffering is possible – complete cessation of thirst; absence of passion and desire
- There is a path to end suffering – the Eightfold Path

Eightfold Path (Ashtanga Marga)

- Right views, Right resolve, Right speech, Right conduct, Right livelihood, Right effort, Right mindfulness, Right concentration

Five Aggregates (Skandhas)

Buddhist philosophy holds that a human being is a compound of five aggregates; clinging to them causes suffering:

- Form – four elements (earth, water, fire, air), sense organs, distinctions of sex
- Consciousness
- Feeling – sensations of pleasure and pain
- Formation

- Perception and Potentialities leading to good or bad results

All five aggregates are impermanent. Consciousness arises from contact with other aggregates.

Cycle of Suffering (Pratityasamutpada)

- Root cause: Ignorance → impressions from previous birth → initial consciousness → mind and body → sense organs → contact with senses → sense experience → thirst for enjoyment → clinging → tendency to be born → rebirth → suffering
- The only way to break this cycle: remove ignorance by acquiring right knowledge

Nirvana – Ultimate Goal

- Not a state reached after death – attainable in this very life
- Sinless calm state of mind; freedom from desires and passions; perfect peace, goodness, and wisdom
- When Nirvana is reached, the cycle of birth and death ends – final liberation

3.6.3 Carvaka School

Overview

- Closely maps to materialism – emphasises life of enjoyment based on pleasure and wealth
- Also called Lokayata
- 'Carvaka' literally means 'sweet-tongued' (caru-vaka) – ideas appear attractive at the outset
- No original canonical text survives; known mostly through refutations by opposing schools

Core Philosophical Positions

- Only direct perception through senses is a valid means of knowledge (Pramana)
- Matter is the ultimate reality; world constituted of four elements only: earth, water, fire, air
- Ether/space not accepted – not directly perceivable
- All transcendental entities rejected: atman, mind, Isvara, dharma, svarga, moksha
- No rebirth, no afterlife – the concept of the 'other world' is dismissed

View on Consciousness and the Self

- No atman (self) other than the body
- When the four elements come together, the body forms and consciousness appears as a by-product
- When elements separate at death, consciousness ceases – there is no after-life
- Goal of life: experience pleasure 'here and now'